

CELEBRATING EXCELLENCE Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, India Today Group Editor-in-Chief Aroon Purie and Editorial Director Raj Chengappa with the winners of the Best Colleges and Universities Awards

A NEW LEARNING ORDER

The India Today Education Conclave explored how governance, technology and pedagogy are converging to redefine India's education system

The educational landscape of India is undergoing a great transformation, driven by policy reforms, technological innovation and shifting societal expectations. The implementation of the National Education Policy 2020 (NEP) has shifted the focus to multidisciplinary learning, skill development and experiential education, while digital tools and AI-powered platforms are reshaping classrooms. Universities and schools are collaborating with industry to make learning more applied and future-ready, and alternative credentials, micro-courses and lifelong learning pathways are gaining traction. At the same time, educators are placing greater emphasis on holistic development, mental health and socio-emotional learning, signalling a shift from rote memorisation to a more learner-centric, flexible and inclusive system that aligns with global standards.

The day-long India Today Education Conclave 2026, held recently in New Delhi, brought together policymakers, educators and thinkers to discuss these issues and chart the future of learning in India.

Union Minister of Education Dharmendra Pradhan, in his keynote address titled 'Policy to Practice: Implementing NEP 2020', emphasised the transformative power of the NEP. He highlighted how the policy aims to build an education system that is holistic, flexible and competency-based, equipping students with skills for the 21st century while promoting cultural and linguistic diversity. He also underscored the importance of learning in one's mother tongue or regional language, asserting that multilingualism strengthens cognitive development and national identity.

The conclave's overarching message was clear—education reforms succeed only when systems foster autonomy, trust, holistic development and a culture of mentorship. The evening concluded with the minister presenting the India Today Best Colleges and Universities Awards 2025 to the heads of leading educational institutions across the country. ■

—Shelly Anand

Photographs by ARUN KUMAR, ATUL KUMAR YADAV